The Reference Request Note

Before you ask a customer to help with a deal

01 What question needs answering?

Write the buyer's actual question. Why is this customer the right person to answer it?

02 What would we ask the customer to give?

State the format, time, audience and deadline. Check prior asks and the exact permission needed. Include the customer's possible benefit without dressing up a favour as a benefit.

03 Is there a smaller way?

Choose: ask as planned, make a smaller ask, use existing proof, or wait. Name the person who will ask and the next step if the customer declines.

Example: a prospect asks about rollout

Fictional example, not a customer result.

Buyer wants to know	First option	Customer ask
What went wrong during rollout?	Approved story	Optional call next week

The story may not answer the whole question. The customer gets a specific, optional request rather than a demand for a call tomorrow.

Copy this prompt. Add your observations.

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Buyer question: [ ]
Exact customer ask: [format, audience, time, deadline]
Why this customer: [ ]
Permission and recent asks checked: [ ]
Smaller option: [ ]
Decision and owner: [ ]
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Use on one live request. The customer's no must remain a real option. Follow your company's permission process for names, quotes and logos.

An editorial decision aid, not a proven way to improve sales or retention. The sources and limits are in the article.